Merve Demirel

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Institute for International Economic Studies
Stockholm University
SE-106 91 Stockholm, Sweden

Email: merve.demirel@iies.su.se
Website: demirelmerve.com
Phone: +46 76 053 24 79
Citizenship: Turkey
Residence: Sweden (permanent)

Education

2020–2027 **Stockholm University (IIES)**, PhD in Economics (expected June 2027)
2024–2025 **Columbia University**, Visiting Scholar, hosted by Laura Boudreau
2017–2019 **Stockholm School of Economics**, MSc in Economics
Exchange semester: University of Tokyo
2012–2017 **Koç University**, BA in Economics, BA in Business
Exchange semesters: National University of Singapore, HEC Paris

References

Johannes Haushofer
Cornell University
haushofer@cornell.edu

Anna Tompsett
Stockholm University
anna.tompsett@iies.su.se

Tessa Bold
Stockholm University
tessa.bold@iies.su.se

Laia Navarro-Sola
Stockholm University
laia.navarrosola@iies.su.se

Research Fields

Development Economics, Labor Economics, Gender

Job Market Paper

Migration Costs and Higher Education: Experimental Evidence from India

Opportunities are unevenly distributed across space. But moving to opportunity can be daunting: potential movers might worry about safety, loneliness, or the difficulties of navigating an unknown city. Such costs are difficult to observe and quantify, however. This paper studies the role of migration costs in one of the most consequential decisions young people make: whether and where to pursue higher education. I ask whether migration costs hold prospective students back from migrating for college, and whether learning about student life in other cities can reduce perceived costs and facilitate migration. I follow 1,682 final-year secondary students across 52 schools in Maharashtra, India, over a full year as they finish school, apply for, and enroll in higher education. First, I measure their perceived migration costs in an incentivized choice experiment and decompose them into beliefs about specific non-pecuniary outcomes at each destination. I then run a randomized controlled trial offering half of them a mentorship program that pairs each student with a university student who migrated for college. At baseline, the average student would forgo a 129% increase in expected post-graduation earnings to avoid studying away from home, an amount that far exceeds the monetary returns students expect and rises steeply with distance. Their beliefs about the difficulty of moving, safety, parental approval, and happiness away from home account for a substantial portion of perceived migration costs. Mentorship increases a pre-specified educational migration index by 0.16 standard deviations, driven by short-distance moves made by male students. Consistent with the stated-preference evidence, these effects are concentrated on the margin where migration costs are smallest, suggesting these costs remain a major obstacle to moving to opportunity.

Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0016735.

Working Papers

Distance, Gender, and Access to Elite Higher Education: Evidence from India's Centralized Engineering Admissions (with Xuanzhe Hou and Yash Kanoria)
Earlier version circulated as "How Far Would You Go? Higher Education and Migration Decisions in India."

Identity and Human Capital Investment: Evidence from the Veiling Ban Removal in Turkey (with Avenia Ghazarian)
HoSS Working Paper 2026-1, Stockholm School of Economics.

Moving to Opportunity Abroad: The Effects of International Educational Migration (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Pérez Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
World Bank Social Policy and Labor Discussion Paper No. 2702. Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0012924.

Educational Migration Prospects and Human Capital Investments: Evidence from a Uganda-Germany College Access Program (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Pérez Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
World Bank Social Policy and Labor Discussion Paper No. 2702. Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0009992.

Work in Progress

International Migration and Identity Formation: The Perception of the Self and Others (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Pérez Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0016846.

Harassment in Colleges: A Bottom-Up Approach (with Eugenia Frezza, Emmanuel Keith Kisaame and Arne Nasgowitz)
Pilot stage. Funded by J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative and Leading House Africa.

Research Grants

2026	**J-PAL**, Displaced Livelihoods Initiative (USD 200,000); **Max Planck Society** (USD 171,300); **ECONtribute** (USD 23,100); **Leading House Africa**, Swiss Tropical and Public Health Institute (USD 17,100)
2025	**J-PAL**, Jobs and Opportunity Initiative / Social Protection Initiative (USD 250,000); **ECONtribute** (USD 67,800); **J-PAL**, Crime and Violence Initiative, Exploratory Research and Travel Grant (USD 9,995)
2024	**Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences** (USD 28,200); **The Weiss Fund**, Travel and Piloting Grant (USD 14,938); **Mannerfelt Foundation** (USD 3,700); **Stockholm Center for Global Asia** (USD 1,400); **SurveyCTO**, Primary Data Collection Research Grant
2023	**World Bank**, Innovation Challenge on Jobs and Migration (USD 279,900); **ECONtribute** (USD 54,100); **PEDL**, Exploratory Research Grant (USD 6,200); **Mannerfelt Foundation** (USD 2,800); **IIES** (USD 1,900)
2022	**ECONtribute** (USD 105,000)

Fellowships and Honors

2021 **Jan Wallander and Tom Hedelius Foundation** (USD 58,300)
2018 **Stockholms Grosshandlarsocietetet**, Scholarship for Studies Abroad (USD 1,700)
2017 **Af Jochnik Foundation**, MSc Scholarship (USD 35,100)
2016 **European Bank for Reconstruction and Development**, Starting Grant
2012 **Koç University**, Full Merit Scholarship

Teaching Experience

2021 **Stockholm University**, Intermediate Microeconomics, TA to Lars Vahtrik
2019 **Stockholm School of Economics**, Introductory Microeconomics, TA to Richard Friberg
2018 **Stockholm School of Economics**, International Economics, TA to Paul Segerström

Research Experience

2018–2020 **Stockholm School of Economics**, Research Assistant for Martina Björkman-Nyqvist, Abhijeet Singh and Pamela Campa
2018 **Stockholm University**, Research Assistant for Anna Tompsett

Talks and Conferences ([†]scheduled)

2026 Oxford Development Economics Workshop; RFBerlin Migration Forum; Women in Economics Network Conference; Talent Economics Conference; ASWEDE Conference[†]; The Economics of Migration Junior Webinar[†]
2025 Tilburg University; University of Groningen; Development Colloquium, Columbia University; Interdisciplinary PhD Workshop in Sustainable Development, Columbia University; SEEDEC, Max Planck Institute Bonn
2024 ASWEDE Conference
2023 European Network Development Conference; ASWEDE Conference
2022 ASWEDE Conference

Refereeing

Journals: *Science*, *Journal of Population Economics*

Service

2020–2023 **Women in Economics Initiative**, Board Member

Other Experience

2016–2017 **Jana Impact**, Co-founder of a social enterprise for refugee employment
2016–2017 **Carma Consultancy**, Business Development Intern

Languages

Turkish (native), English (fluent), Swedish (intermediate), French (beginner)